Mole and Ratty and the River Picnic



A bedtime story for ages 4–7



Mole woke up one bright spring morning in his little house under the ground. The sun was shining through his round window, and the birds were singing, but Mole was busy spring-cleaning. He scrubbed the floor. He dusted the shelves. He polished the brass knob on his front door till it shone.

But then Mole stopped. He looked at his broom, and he looked at the sunshine, and he said, "Spring cleaning can wait. Today I am going out to see the spring!"



So Mole dug up, up, up through the soft earth — pop! — and tumbled out onto the green grass. Oh! The meadow was wide and bright, full of buttercups and daisies, and the air smelled of warm earth and new leaves. Mole had never been above ground before, and everything was new.



Mole scampered across the meadow until he heard a soft, silvery sound — shush, shush, shush. It was the river! Wide and blue, it sparkled in the sunshine, and on it floated a little blue boat. In the boat sat a brown water rat with bright eyes and a friendly smile.



"Hello!" called the Rat. "I am Ratty. Would you like to come aboard?"



Mole had never been in a boat. But Ratty's smile was so kind that Mole climbed in, and Ratty showed him the river as they drifted along — past the bending willows, past the ducks and their yellow ducklings, past a kingfisher, bright as a jewel, darting past like a flying spark.



"Would you like to try rowing?" asked Ratty. Mole nodded and took the oars. He pulled one way — wobble! He pulled the other way — splash! The little boat tipped and rocked, and a cold wave splashed right over Mole's nose. "Oh no!" squeaked Mole. "I have spoiled it all!"



Ratty laughed — not a mean laugh, a warm, sunny laugh. "Not a bit of it," he said, steadying the boat with one paw. "Everyone wobbles the first time. The river is for sharing, and sharing means learning together."



So Ratty spread a picnic on the grassy bank — crusty bread and yellow cheese, fat red strawberries, and lemonade that fizzed in the sun. They ate until they were full, and talked till the sun turned gold and the river turned to ribbons of pink.



When it was time to go home, Ratty walked Mole to his little front door. "Come again tomorrow," said Ratty. "The river will be here, and so will I."



That night, Mole curled up in his soft bed and dreamed the river still sparkled, and Ratty was still smiling. He had gone out to see the spring — and he had found a friend.

Sleep now, little Mole.

The end. ■